AYE
TECH HUB

• PLUMBING ENGINEERING • LESSON 02

Plumbing Tools and Safety

The Complete Toolkit — Hand Tools, Power Tools, PPE

Lesson 02 of 30 | Plumbing Engineering Programme | AYE Tech Hub

Awet G. Nway

Founder, AYE Tech Hub | MEP & Plumbing Engineering Expert

- 25 essential hand tools — every plumber must own these before their first job
- Power tools for plumbing: pipe threading machines, drain snakes, press tools
- Pipe joining tools: soldering kit, push-fit, compression, press-fit systems
- Pressure testing equipment — how to test for leaks before closing up walls
- PPE requirements: what to wear and why — burns, cuts, chemicals, Legionella
- The 6 biggest plumbing hazards and how to control each one
- Hot works permits, confined space entry, and working at height safely

Why the Right Tool Makes All the Difference

A plumber without the correct tools is not a plumber — they are a person standing next to a pipe. The right tool turns a 2-hour job into a 20-minute job. The wrong tool damages fittings, creates leaks, and produces work that fails inspection. Investing in quality tools is not an expense — it is the foundation of a professional practice.

This lesson covers the complete toolkit for a practising plumber: essential hand tools, power tools, pipe-joining equipment, testing gear, and safety equipment. For each tool, we explain what it does, when to use it, and what to look for when buying.

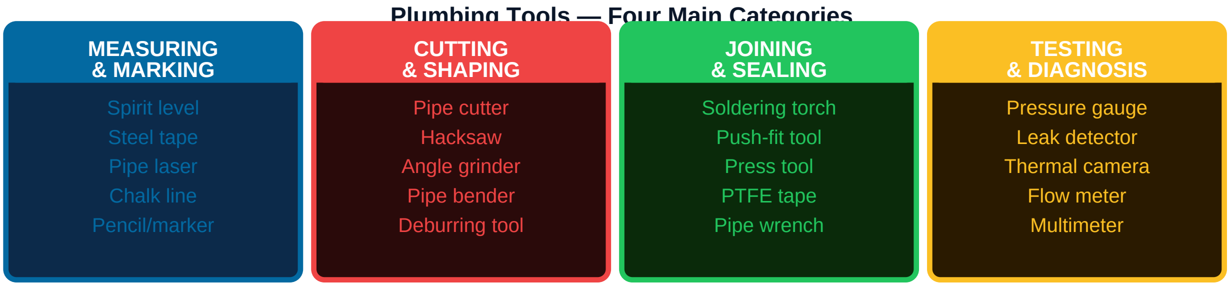

Fig 1 — Every plumber needs tools from all four categories before starting any job

Essential Hand Tools — The Core Kit

These are the tools every plumber must own before taking on any job. They are used on virtually every installation and repair. Buy quality — cheap tools fail at the worst moments.

Tool	Purpose	Key Specification	Buying Tip
Pipe wrench (Stillson)	Grip and turn round pipes and fittings. Adjustable jaw bites harder as you apply more force.	300mm (12") for most work; 450mm (18") for larger pipes	Buy two — one to hold the pipe, one to turn the fitting. Ridgid or Irwin brands are industry standard.
Basin wrench	Tighten tap back-nuts in tight spaces under basins and sinks where a standard wrench cannot reach.	300–450mm reach; spring-loaded pivoting jaw	Essential for basin and sink tap installation — cannot substitute any other tool.
Adjustable spanner (Crescent wrench)	General-purpose gripping for hexagonal nuts, compression fittings, and valves.	250mm (10") and 300mm (12") — carry both	Use jaw-side pulling, not pushing, to prevent slipping and rounding the fitting.
Pipe cutter (wheel cutter)	Cuts copper, stainless, and chrome pipe cleanly and squarely without burrs.	3–35mm (mini) and 3–76mm (standard) range	Always deburr the cut end after cutting — rough edges restrict flow and damage seals.
Hacksaw with spare blades	Cuts steel pipe, plastic pipe, and threaded rod. Slower than a pipe cutter but handles more materials.	32 TPI blade for steel; 18 TPI for plastic; always keep spare blades	Blades dull quickly in steel — replace at first sign of blade wandering or burning smell.

Pipe bender (manual)	Bends copper pipe to any angle without kinking or flattening the bore.	15mm and 22mm formers as standard; 28mm for larger supply runs	Use pipe bending springs inside copper pipe as backup when formal bender is unavailable — prevents wall collapse.
Deburring tool (reamer)	Removes sharp internal burrs from inside cut pipe ends — essential before every joint.	3–42mm multi-size rotary reamer	Burrs inside pipe restrict flow by up to 30% and shred O-ring seals. Never skip this step.
Blowtorch and solder kit	Solder (tin/silver) copper pipe joints. Gas torch + fireproof mat + lead-free solder + flux	MAPP gas burns hotter than propane — better for 28mm+ pipe	Always use lead-free solder (BS EN 29453) for potable water. Never use lead solder on drinking water pipes.
PTFE tape (Teflon tape)	Thread sealer for male threaded joints — wraps around male thread before tightening.	White 12mm tape for water; yellow 12mm for gas	Apply 3–5 full wraps in the direction of the thread — clockwise when facing the thread end.
Spirit level (magnetic)	Ensure pipework, fixtures, and radiators are level and plumb.	400mm (16") and 600mm (24") versions	Magnetic versions stick to steel pipes and radiators, freeing both hands.

Measuring, Marking, and Layout Tools

Tool	Use in Plumbing	Key Specification
Steel tape measure	Measure pipe runs, wall offsets, fixture positions	8m minimum length; lockable; with end hook
Pencil and marker	Mark cut lines on pipe, fixture positions on walls	Permanent marker (Sharpie) for metal; pencil for timber/plasterboard
Chalk line	Mark long straight lines on walls or floors for pipe routes	15–30m chalk line; blue chalk for temporary, red for permanent
Pipe laser level	Project a level or plumb line over long distances — essential for long drain pipe runs	Self-levelling laser, 15m+ range; marks correct fall angle for drains
Square (combination)	Check square cuts and 45° angles for pipe offsets	300mm combination square with protractor and level vial
Profile gauge (contour gauge)	Copy complex profiles (tile edges, curved walls) for precise pipe penetration marking	250mm width; spring-loaded pins

Power Tools for Plumbing

Power tools dramatically speed up plumbing installation — especially drilling through joists, threading steel pipe, and press-fitting connections. Always use power tools with appropriate PPE and in accordance with the manufacturer's safe operating procedure.

Power Tool	Plumbing Application	Key Specification	Safety Note
Cordless drill / driver (18V)	Drill pipe holes through joists and studs; drive fixings for pipe clips and brackets	18V lithium; 13mm chuck; hammer drill function for masonry	Use sharp drill bits — blunt bits overheat and can cause the drill to jump. Always drill away from electrical cables and pipes hidden in walls.
Angle grinder (115mm)	Cut steel pipe and cast iron; remove corrosion from threads; grind welds	115mm or 125mm; 1,000W minimum; variable speed beneficial	Highest-risk power tool. Always wear full face shield, leather gloves, and fire-resistant clothing. Sparks travel 5m+ and ignite combustibles.
Pipe threading machine	Cut threads on steel pipe for threaded joints — essential for gas and fire sprinkler work	Ridgid 300 or equivalent; handles 6–50mm pipe diameter	Use correct die set for pipe size. Apply threading oil throughout. Clean chips from thread before applying joint compound.
Electric drain snake (auger)	Clear blocked drains — cable extends into drain and breaks up or retrieves blockage	15–30m cable; 230V or battery; 50mm–100mm head attachments	Secure loose clothing and hair before operating — cable can grab and cause severe injury. Wear goggles (water spray from drain).
Press fitting tool (Viega/Geberit)	Permanently press-connect push-fit fittings on copper, steel, or stainless pipe in seconds — no flame required	Battery-powered; 12–108mm press range; correct jaw profile for fitting brand	An unpressed connection looks identical to a pressed one — always use the tool's "go/no-go" indicator and inspect every connection before concealing.
Wet and dry vacuum	Remove water from drain downs, capture pipe swarf and drilling debris during installation	30–80 litre capacity; HEPA filter for fine dust	Never vacuum live electrical connections or asbestos-containing materials without specialist equipment.

PRESS FITTING TECHNOLOGY — The most significant tool innovation in plumbing in 20 years. Press fittings eliminate the need for open flames entirely, making installation faster, safer, and permitted in fire-sensitive environments (hospitals, data centres, occupied buildings). A trained operator can press 50+ joints per hour vs 10–15 soldered joints per hour. Now standard in most commercial plumbing specifications.

Pipe Joining Methods — Choosing the Right Connection

Method	Materials	Skill Level	Speed	Permitted In	Key Rule

Solder (end-feed/capillary)	Copper only	Medium	Slow	Most locations	Lead-free solder only for potable water. Clean and flux pipe before heating. Heat fitting, not pipe.
Compression fitting	Copper, chrome, stainless, PEX	Easy	Fast	Anywhere	Do not overtighten — 1.5 turns past hand tight is usually correct. Overtightening crushes olive and causes leaks.
Push-fit (Speedfit, Hep2O)	Copper, PEX, CPVC plastic	Beginner	Very fast	Most domestic	Pipe must be cut square and fully deburred. Push to full depth (check insertion depth mark). Use deinsert tool to disconnect.
Press fitting (M-press)	Copper, steel, stainless	Trained	Very fast	All including commercial	Must use correct press jaw for fitting brand. Unpressed joints look correct — always check every joint with inspection mirror.
Solvent weld (PVC/ABS)	uPVC, ABS plastic	Easy	Fast but cure time needed	Cold drainage only (not hot supply)	Apply primer then cement. Push and hold 30 seconds. Full cure 24 hours before pressure testing.
Threaded (BSP/NPT)	Steel, brass, malleable iron	Medium	Medium	Gas, fire, industrial	Apply PTFE tape or thread sealant compound. Never overtighten — cracks fittings. For gas: always use approved compound, never PTFE alone.
Flanged	All materials	Advanced	Slow	Large diameter, removable joints	Correct gasket material for fluid and temperature. Tighten bolts in star (cross) pattern to even compression.

Testing Equipment — Proving Your Work Is Leak-Free

All plumbing work must be pressure-tested before walls are closed and systems are commissioned. A leak discovered after plastering and decoration costs 10–100 times more to fix than one found before. Pressure testing is not optional — it is a professional requirement and often a legal one under building regulations.

Test	Equipment Needed	Procedure Summary	Pass Criteria
Cold water supply pressure test	Test pump, pressure gauge (0–10 bar), hose connections	Isolate system. Connect pump to lowest point. Fill with water. Pump to 1.5× working pressure (min. 6 bar for mains systems). Monitor 30–60 minutes.	No pressure drop over test period. No visible leaks at any joint or fitting.

Hot water system test	Same as cold water test	Test at cold before heating. Check expansion vessel pre-charge pressure (typically 1 bar cold).	No pressure drop. Expansion vessel correctly charged. PRV set-pressure confirmed.
Drain pressure test (watertight test)	Inflatable drain plugs, water fill, dip rod	Plug all outlets below test level. Fill drain with water to inspection chamber level. Allow 30 minutes to stabilise. Measure water level.	Water level must not drop more than 25mm in the first hour after 30-minute stabilisation period (NHBC/BS EN standard).
Air test (drainage)	Air test pump, manometer (U-gauge), rubber bungs	Plug all openings. Pump to 38mm water gauge (WG). Wait 3 minutes. Read final pressure.	Pressure must not drop below 25mm WG after 3 minutes. Identifies trap seal failures and open joints.
Leak detection (thermal camera)	Thermal imaging camera	After pressurisation, scan all pipe routes and joints. Cold water leaks show as cold spots; hot water shows as warm anomalies.	No thermal anomalies at joints. Useful for finding leaks behind walls without opening up.

Plumbing Safety — The Six Main Hazards

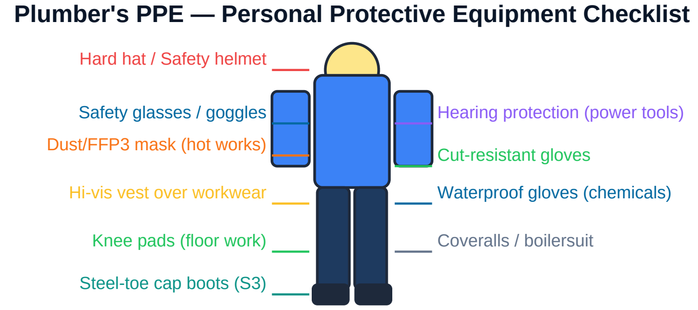

Fig 2 — PPE must match the specific task: soldering requires heat-resistant gloves; chemical work requires chemical-resistant gloves

Fig 3 — Higher severity + higher likelihood = higher priority control measures required

Hazard	Risk	Control Measures
Scalding from hot water	Burns from uncontrolled hot water release during drain-downs or when working on pressurised hot water systems	Always cold down system before working on hot water circuits. Warn building occupants before opening hot taps. Wear heat-resistant gloves when working near boilers.

Burns from soldering	Burns from open flame torch, hot copper pipe, and molten solder. Risk of fire from nearby combustibles.	Use fireproof mat behind all soldering joints. Keep fire extinguisher within reach. Apply cold wet cloth to pipe after soldering before touching. Never leave torch unattended.
Chemical exposure	Skin and eye burns from flux, solvent cement, drain cleaning chemicals (caustic soda, acid)	Wear chemical-resistant gloves and safety glasses for all chemical use. Read COSHH data sheet for every chemical before first use. Ensure good ventilation.
Legionella bacteria	Lung infection (Legionnaires' disease) from aerosol mist of contaminated water at 25–45°C. Can be fatal.	Keep hot water cylinders at 60°C+. Do not disturb stagnant water without FFP3 face mask. Notify FM team when working on cooling towers or hot water systems in large buildings.
Manual handling injuries	Back injury from lifting heavy cast iron pipes, boilers, and cylinders	Use mechanical aids (trolleys, pipe stands) for items over 20kg. Two-person lift for anything over 25kg. Attend manual handling training annually.
Cuts from tools and pipe	Lacerations from pipe cutters, hacksaw blades, sheet metal edges, and copper pipe burrs	Wear cut-resistant gloves when cutting pipe. Deburr all pipe ends immediately after cutting. Store tools safely — never leave cutting tools exposed in a tool bag.

Hot Works Permit — Required for Soldering in Buildings

In most commercial, public, and multi-occupancy buildings, soldering requires a **hot works permit** — a formal written document issued by the site manager that authorises the use of a naked flame. The permit specifies the location, duration, fire precautions required, and a 30-minute fire watch period after completion. Failure to obtain a hot works permit before soldering is a disciplinary offence on most sites and can invalidate the building's fire insurance. Always ask: "Does this site require a hot works permit?" before setting up your torch.

PRACTICAL RULE — If you are ever unsure whether you need a hot works permit, assume YES and ask the site manager before starting. Press fittings completely eliminate the need for hot works permits and are the recommended alternative wherever soldering would require a permit.

Key Takeaways — PLUMB-002: Plumbing Tools and Safety

• **Tools are divided into four categories:** measuring/marking, cutting/shaping, joining/sealing, and testing/diagnosis. A professional plumber needs tools from all four.

• **Never skip deburring** after cutting pipe — burrs restrict flow by up to 30% and destroy O-ring seals in push-fit fittings.

• **Use lead-free solder only** on drinking water pipes. Lead solder is illegal for potable water in the UK, EU, and most countries.

• **Press fittings are the modern standard** — faster than soldering, no naked flame, permitted in all buildings including occupied ones.

• **Pressure test every system before closing up** — the same leak that costs 30 minutes to fix before plastering can cost £3,000+ to fix after.

• **PPE must match the hazard** — chemical-resistant gloves for flux/solvents, heat-resistant for soldering, cut-resistant for pipe cutting. General gloves protect against none of these adequately.

• **Always ask about hot works permits** before soldering in any commercial, public, or multi-occupancy building. Press fittings eliminate this requirement entirely.

• **Next lesson — PLUMB-003:** Pipe Materials and Types — detailed comparison of every pipe material used in modern plumbing with selection guide by application.